



The Indian Angle: Trine Studios, Mumbai

So what's the game development scene in India like? We spoke to Somil Gupta, Managing Director, Trine Animation Studios Ltd, Mumbai about their organisation, gaming in general, and upcoming titles.

Trine consists of a team that is 80 members strong. 70 of these are developers and animation artists. Sangam Gupta, Somil's brother and Trine's CEO tells us that their strategy is to attack the international market with localised content, somewhat like what the Japanese have done with ninjas and samurais in their games.

The stages involved in game development according to Somil are Conceptual design, preproduction, production, alpha, beta, gold.

When asked about game titles, Somil is all about the Indian angle to gaming. He feels Indian folklore, locations, and even mythical events all have enough subject matter to capture the interest of the Indian gamer. We seem to agree that an

Indian flavour to such games is certain to attract a larger audience in India, especially, those completely new to the world of games. From a marketing standpoint, this strategy could well work in Trine's favour, and succeed where other Indian developers have failed.

Trine's current flagship is called *Legends of Great India* and is an RTS game based around mythical and religious characters like Hanuman, Ganesha, Rama and Arjuna. The goal of this game is to save India from all evil including Ravana and his minions. Get set to use a fantastic array of powers and control armies of hundreds of troops. Although the plot may seem simple, it's the implementation that we're interested to see when this game is finally out. Somil tells us they use cutting edge graphics in their titles and this game is based around DX 9 SM3, and even DX 10 implementations are being experimented with.

The other two titles in development are *Streets of Mumbai*, which is an *NFS*

Carbon-like game based around the streets of Mumbai, as we know, which are home to many (sometimes) illegal races. In this game, you can upgrade and mod your car with cash you acquire by winning street races. There are as many as 20 cars to choose from and a variety of eye-candy mods like rims, paint jobs, lights, hoods, side skirts and bumpers to choose from.

Wings of Control the other game Trine is working on, is an aerial combat based game focussed on tactical dogfights. You can choose from between seven models of fighter planes, and the game is based around an alternate world scenario where you fight for aerial domination. This title promises to be a LAN gamers delight.

With some rather unique titles in the pipe, we're really interested to see where Trine takes this bold initiative. For us gamers, more game studios in India can only be a good thing, as competition will lead to improved content, and gameplay. All we can tell Trine is to "bring em on".

marketers, retailers, buyers, distributors, hardware vendors, and other specialists in the channel, working to guarantee a successful product launch.

The amount of work involved in actually creating a game, let alone promoting, circulating and distributing it, seems mind boggling. Considering that the development cycle for a single game could be as long as four years there's a huge timeframe involved in each of these stages. Loads of work and sleepless nights are expected, even for a team that is as gifted as Epic's team of programmers, designers and testers.

It was now quarter to three in the afternoon, and we were shown into a large darkened hall. This, according to Cliffy is where all the parties and frag fests occur. There were four rows of desks, each with five chairs neatly arranged. Each seat had an X360 hooked up to a small 22-inch LCD TV, and (surprise!) *GOW 2* was running on each of these systems. It seems the Epic team had arranged for us to go head-to-head, and there were four five-man teams organised, most of the players were of course Epic and Microsoft employees, who from the looks of it, had spent several hundred hours apiece on the original game. The prize for the winning team—an X360 Elite console system for each player—wow! A few sniper headshots and gory chainsaw melees later, it was clear that our team sucked. However, the forgiving nature of Epic's team and *GOW 2*, allowed us to improve somewhat and our team managed to reach

the finals where we lost spectacularly to a five man squad solely from Epic. Their role in the company—game testers—damn!

After this three-hour session, a few people stayed behind, to play the game some more. Although this isn't really a preview, our impression is *Gears Of War 2* seems a lot more polished and balanced than the original. There've been minor tweaks done to map visibility around the character. The player-controlled character's body movements themselves have been subtly reworked. There're a couple of new weapons including a well done (pun intended) flame thrower, and each weapon gets a new, gorier finishing animation. There're also a couple of new map styles for the multi-player components. The single player campaign is equally robust, and we're told, more movie-like in terms of plot twists.

By around 6:30 pm we were done, after which we had a quick snack and a Coke with Epic, discussing our impressions of the game and exchanging opinions. Another half hour later, we were aboard a bus to our hotel room. Thus, concluded a tour, which has left many good impressions firmly entrenched in our noggins. Firstly, games aren't easy-to-design (a gross understatement this). Secondly, Epic's working environs totally rock! Thirdly, *GOW 2* seems the real deal, and all set to make an even bigger splash than it's predecessor did back in 2006. Lastly, November can't get here soon enough! ☒

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